

AP



Igniting a New Row

AHMEDABAD Think of the 2002 Godhra carnage and the subsequent Gujarat riots and truth is the first casualty. The G.T. Nanavati Commission—appointed by the Gujarat Government in 2002 to probe the violence and subsequent riots—last month confirmed the investigations of Rakesh Asthana, a Gujarat cadre IPS officer. Asthana had alleged that the 59 Hindus aboard S6 coach of the Sabarmati Express were burnt to death following a

conspiracy by the accused. All except two of the 131 Muslim accused have been arrested.

The Commission's report has led to an uproar in the country's human rights lobby. Despite contrary evidence, human rights activists have defended the Godhra accused by portraying the incident as an accident or even a conspiracy by the Sangh Parivar to kill Hindus and trigger an anti-Muslim backlash with an eye on Hindu votes.

BLOOD ON THE TRACKS: The Sabarmati Express

The Commission's interim report pointed out that the 1,000-strong Muslim mob which attacked the train was instigated by the accused in order to camouflage their plan to kill Ramsevakhs coming from Ayodhya.

The noises on the report were familiar. Said an elated Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi, "Those who said the Godhra carnage was due to an accident must now apologise to the people of Gujarat." On the other hand, human rights activist Teesta Setalvad tore the report apart, calling it a sham tailored to suit Modi's designs.

The next and final part of the report on how the anti-Muslim riots occurred after the Godhra carnage and the government's role in it will be out by the end of December. It may well lead to greater controversy. Seemingly, the passage of time hasn't calmed this bloody chapter yet.

by Uday Mahurkar

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: C.P. Balan Vaidyar, 72, CPI(M)'s Kerala State Control Commission chairman and a three-time MLA from Kunnammangalam.

DIED: Singer Mahendra Kapoor, 74. He received the national award for best male playback singing for *Mere Desh Ki Dharti* in



the film *Upkar*. He was also a Padma Shri awardee.

DIED: Mahinder Singh Saathi, 76, ex-mayor of Delhi and Congress leader. He was minister of planning and finance in the Delhi government in 1998.

DIED: Former Supreme Court Judge K. Venkataswami, 75, who conducted the inquiry into the Tehelka case relating to the corruption exposé in defence deals.

WON: By Chetan Anand, 28, the Czech International badminton tournament.

VIS-A-VIS J. JAYALALITHAA AIADMK chief versus M. KARUNANIDHI Tamil Nadu chief minister

AIADMK is the only party that ensured full protection to Muslims. They should continue their support to me.



SAURABH SINGH

Muslims are aware of how she had reacted to their demand for exclusive reservation by enacting the anti-conversion law.

EPILOGUE: Tamil Nadu's Muslims will have the last word in the next elections.